

CIRCUMCISION, DEVELOPMENTAL IMPAIRMENT,
AND LIFE-LONG CONSEQUENCES

Marilyn Faye Milos, R.N.

Address to the Fourth International Congress of the Pre- & Perinatal Psychology
Association of North America - August, 1989

During a newborn circumcision, a baby is strapped spread-eagle to a plastic board and then, usually without anesthesia, a normal, healthy part of his penis is cut off. This alarming practice has become extremely controversial over the past few years, following the 1975 declaration of the American Academy of Pediatrics: "There is no absolute medical indication for routine circumcision of the newborn."

One might have thought that such a statement would be sufficient to bring an end to a practice that most of the world has never even considered. Eighty-five percent of the world's male population is not circumcised. But circumcision has a string irrational bias that seeks validation and the American medical community continues its attempt to justify this unwarranted surgery.

As with any surgical procedure, circumcision has inherent risks including hemorrhage, infection, mutilation and death. While these risks have been recognized albeit minimized, we have been entirely remiss in acknowledging the potential psychological risks of inflicting the pain of circumcision on newborns. For that reason, I am glad to bring this important infant rights issue to the Fourth International Congress on Pre- and Perinatal Psychology.

The doctor performs the surgery on the newborn baby's healthy, normal penis by crushing, slicing, clamping and amputating the foreskin - all without anesthesia. If this surgery was not performed behind the mask of medicine or religion, the act would be considered sexual child abuse, torture, and mutilation. If it was performed on baby girls it would be considered an atrocity.

It has generally been assumed that babies do not feel pain during circumcision. This, in fact, may have been true when mothers were routinely anesthetized for birth and babies were routinely circumcised in the delivery room. As recipients of their mothers' medication, babies may not have felt the pain of the surgery or were so drugged that they simply did not react to it.

With the advent of natural childbirth, however, things changed. Babies began to scream from the pain. Why didn't doctors notice? Why did they perpetuate the myth that babies didn't feel pain when they could hear them scream and watch them turn blue, vomit or defecate during the surgery? Perhaps it was because the medical community had determined that responses to pain were reflexive, that perception of pain was not localized or present, or that babies had a high pain threshold as an adaptive modality to what was considered the pain of birth. We should also consider Dr. Wilhelm Reich's observation, i.e., anyone who has repressed a feeling in himself will be incapable of recognizing the expression of that same feeling in someone else. This, of course, makes empathy impossible.